

Is a Finance Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

8.0

AI EXPOSURE · ENTRY ANALYST / RESEARCH

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.



Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. If you open with a risk number, they either get frightened and shut down, or defensive about a decision they've already made.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation.

A practical note: there's a separate short version written directly to them. Send them that one.

And two things specific to finance.

The timing matters more here than in any other profile. Investment banking summer analyst applications now open up to eighteen months in advance, which means the decision is effectively made in the first year of university rather than the third. If that route is of any interest, this is a conversation to have before they start, not during.

And be careful with the sources. Finance is unusually well covered by recruiting firms with a commercial interest in optimism. We've leaned on Bureau of Labor Statistics data where possible and flagged where we're relying on industry commentary instead.

The short answer

Yes for the relationship and judgment tiers — advising people, managing risk, owning decisions. Much less so for the spreadsheet tier, which is both the most automatable work we score in this family and the traditional way in.

Wealth and financial advisory scores **4.6** out of 10. An entry-level analyst role scores **8.0**.

Finance protects the person in the room with the client, and offers very little to the person preparing the materials for that room.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Wealth / financial advisory	3.9	4.2	4.6	+0.7	Low–Moderate
Risk & compliance	4.5	4.8	5.3	+0.8	Moderate
Investment banking (senior)	4.9	5.3	5.7	+0.8	Moderate
Corporate finance / FP&A	6.0	6.4	6.8	+0.8	Moderate–High
Entry analyst / research	6.4	7.3	8.0	+1.6	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, CPA advisory scores 5.2, a business analyst 7.6, and entry-level software development 8.1.

Read the table this way: the spread is 3.4 points — one of the widest we measure — and it falls almost exactly along the line of who is personally answerable to a client.

Why finance scores the way it does — the six factors

Here's how an entry-level analyst answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

Nearly all of it, and this is the cleanest example in the index of a role built entirely from automatable tasks.

Financial modelling and scenario building. Company and sector research. Earnings analysis and comparables. Pitch book and deck production. Data assembly and cleaning. First-draft memos and commentary.

That list is a substantially complete description of a first-year analyst's job. Not adjacent to it — it is it.

What resists: sitting across from someone making the biggest financial decision of their life, judgment on risks that don't match historical patterns, being called when markets fall, and regulatory accountability for advice given.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Severe, and compounded by something our framework doesn't measure.

Industry commentary consistently reports hiring as **strongest at associate and vice-president level rather than analyst level** — firms buying experience rather than building it, the same pattern documented in law and consulting.

And there's a supply problem alongside it. Finance attracts enormous application volumes at the glamorous end while risk, compliance and operations roles struggle to fill. Two entirely different labour markets sharing a degree.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

None of it. Finance is text and numbers in, judgments out. No physical protection at all.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the advisory tier absolutely; at the analyst tier barely at all. Section 4 covers this properly, because it does most of the work in this profile.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

For regulated advice, meaningfully.

Licensing, registration and fiduciary or suitability obligations attach to a named human advisor. **Regulatory accountability cannot be delegated to a system, and it moves at the speed of legislation rather than technology.**

For an unregulated analyst producing internal materials, none of this applies.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At the advisory and risk tiers frequently. A client's circumstances are individual, and risk judgments on non-pattern events are exactly where models are weakest. Building a comparables table is the opposite.

The person in the room versus the person preparing for it

Finance is almost entirely screen-based. Nobody in it is protected by physical presence. So one factor does most of the work separating a 4.6 from an 8.0, and it's worth understanding precisely.

Two things sit inside our trust factor. *Trust*: does someone need a specific human they can rely on? *Accountability*: must a human carry responsibility when it goes wrong?

A financial advisor rates 9.0 on both. Clients hand over decisions about retirement, a house, a child's education, an inheritance. When markets fall they want to speak to a person who knows their situation and can be held to the advice they gave. Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a licensed human.

An entry-level analyst rates 4.0. They produce work someone else signs off. No client knows their name. Nobody relies on them personally, and no regulatory obligation attaches to them individually. **The work is real and the accountability sits above them.**

The pattern generalises across this whole index: exposure falls as personal accountability rises. The further a role sits from someone answering for the outcome, the more exposed it is — which is why the model consistently finds senior work safer than junior work in every profession lacking a physical or licensing moat.

The uncomfortable implication for a finance graduate is that the protection cannot be acquired at the start. It has to be earned, and the roles where you traditionally earned it are the ones being compressed.

One honest caveat about the trend

Finance is the most cyclical profession we score, and that makes its three-year movement harder to read than any other.

Deal activity slumped sharply in 2023–24 and recovered as rates stabilised. Hiring moved with it. So some portion of the +1.6 on the analyst track is almost certainly the deal cycle rather than automation, and we cannot cleanly separate the two.

What persuades us to hold a high score is the content of the surviving roles rather than their count. Major firms have begun testing whether candidates can direct AI through modelling and research rather than perform it, including in final-round interviews. When a profession redesigns what a first-year is for, the apprenticeship has changed even if headcount recovers.

A graduate can get the analyst seat and still not get the training the seat used to provide.

What we're watching: analyst class sizes through a full deal cycle. If they return to pre-2023 levels and the work returns with them, our score is too high and we'll lower it.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Strong at advisory tier	Most durable	Clients want a person answerable for their money. Socially and legally rooted.
Regulatory / licensing	Real for regulated advice	Durable	Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a named human.
Judgment under novelty	Real at risk and advisory tiers	Eroding slowly	Non-pattern risk judgment resists; standard analysis does not.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Finance has never had this.

The honest read. Finance's protections are genuine and both are seniority-dependent. A graduate has neither on day one, and the traditional route to acquiring them is the part under pressure.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the model	Directing the model build, then interrogating it
Researching the company	Verifying research that arrived pre-assembled
Producing the deck	Deciding what the deck should argue
Learning the sector by covering it exhaustively	Learning it... some other way
Advising a client	Unchanged

The fourth row is the real problem. Analysts learned a sector by building every model in it and being corrected. That was brutal and it was the education. Nobody has replaced it, and the profession is running the experiment on a cohort without a control group.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Client trust in a crisis** — being the person someone calls when markets fall or their

circumstances change. The most durable thing in this profile.

2. **Accountability for advice** — carrying fiduciary responsibility. 3. **Judgment on non-pattern risk** — the event with no historical analogue, which is by

definition what models miss.

4. **Deciding what question to ask** — the judgment upstream of any analysis. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated model or a research summary is confidently

wrong.

Notably absent: modelling speed, Excel fluency and volume of research produced. These were the traditional markers of a strong analyst and are the fastest-depreciating.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The destinations are excellent and the pay is real. Investment banking analyst roles start around \$85,000–\$100,000, among the highest graduate starting salaries in any field, and progression is fast for those who stay.

BLS projects **9% growth for financial analysts** — solid, and above the average across all occupations.

What people in finance report as rewarding:

- **Consequence** — the decisions involve real money and real outcomes
- **Pace of learning**, especially in the first few years, which is genuinely steep
- **Intellectual variety** across sectors, companies and situations

- **Optionality** — finance exits into private equity, corporate strategy, industry leadership and entrepreneurship more readily than most careers
- **The advisory relationship**, which people at that end describe in terms much closer to vocation than transaction

And one structural advantage worth naming: the advisory tier is genuinely under-supplied while the glamorous tier is over-subscribed. Everyone applies to investment banking; far fewer apply to wealth management, risk and compliance — which score better and hire more readily.

What's genuinely hard about it

The hours at the banking end are as bad as their reputation, and they are worst during exactly the years many people are forming other parts of their lives.

Geographic concentration is real. Hiring concentrates heavily in a small number of financial centres. That is a life decision as much as a career one.

Competition at entry is extreme, with record application volumes against selective hiring.

And the recruiting timeline is genuinely punishing. Summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance, and full-time offers go primarily to candidates who did the internship. A student who starts thinking about this in year three has, in practical terms, already missed it.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Finance tends to suit people who:

- **Are comfortable with consequence** — being wrong costs money that belongs to someone else
- **Can hold detail and narrative simultaneously** — the numbers and what they mean
- **Are genuinely commercially curious**, not just good at maths
- **Handle pressure without deteriorating**, sustained rather than occasional
- **Can build trust with people older and wealthier than them**, which is the advisory core

It's harder for people who:

- Want **predictable hours** in the first decade
- Need **geographic flexibility**

- Are drawn primarily by **prestige or salary**, who are heavily over-represented among those who leave in years two and three
- Find **sustained high-stakes pressure** corrosive rather than energising

What else is moving this market

The cycle dominates the short-term picture, which is why section 5 exists.

Where demand is actually growing is not where students are looking. Industry commentary points consistently to restructuring and debt advisory, private capital and secondaries, and risk and compliance driven by regulatory expansion. **Meanwhile applications concentrate on the roles that are hardest to get and most exposed at entry.**

And an unusual tailwind worth knowing: technology, data-centre and digital-infrastructure financing is one of the fastest-growing coverage areas — the AI buildout creating finance work in the same way it created electrical work.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: finance was among the earliest adopters, and major firms now explicitly test whether candidates can direct these tools rather than merely use them.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE FINANCE PROFESSIONAL LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Verify.** Knowing when a generated model or research summary is confidently wrong. **This requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number, which is exactly what the old modelling years used to build.**
- 2. Direct.** Framing an analysis precisely enough to get usable output. Firms are testing this explicitly, which tells you how much they value it.
- 3. Judge what matters.** Deciding which question is worth answering — the layer above the analysis, and the one that doesn't automate.
- 4. Build trust early.** Everything in this profile points at the advisory relationship. Anything that puts a graduate in front of clients sooner moves them up the scale.
- 5. Understand where models fail.** Risk work specifically rewards knowing why a model is wrong about a non-pattern event — which is the entire job in a crisis.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before university: understand the recruiting timeline. If investment banking is of any interest, the process starts in first year. This is the single most actionable fact in this profile.

During: get the internship — it is now the primary filter for full-time offers, not one input among several. Take genuinely quantitative modules. Build the habit of interrogating numbers rather than producing them.

Choosing a destination: consider wealth advisory, risk and compliance seriously. They score better, they hire more readily, and almost nobody your age is applying to them.

The routes in

ROUTE	NOTES
Finance or economics degree → analyst programme	The standard route. Internship-driven, and the timeline starts early.
Any degree + strong quantitative evidence	More common than students assume, particularly in risk and quantitative roles.
Wealth management / advisory training	Less competitive entry, better score, chronically under-applied to.
Risk and compliance	Growing with regulatory expansion, and struggling to fill.
Accounting → finance	A well-worn path, and the CPA travels well.

Where a finance degree can take them later

Genuinely broad: investment banking and capital markets, private equity and asset management, wealth and financial advisory, risk and compliance, corporate finance and treasury, fintech, and industry leadership including CFO tracks.

The pattern in this index holds exactly. Roles where a named human is answerable to a client or a regulator score better. Roles that produce analysis for someone else to act on score worse. That is the whole map, and it applies at every level of seniority.

What to look for in a finance program

1. **Internship placement rate — and which employers.** Given that full-time offers flow primarily from internships, this is the number that matters most.
 2. **Recruiting support that starts in first year.** Programmes that begin careers support in year two are already late for banking.
 3. **Genuine quantitative depth.** Statistics, econometrics, financial modelling taught as reasoning rather than as software training.
 4. **Breadth beyond banking.** Does the programme place into wealth management, risk and compliance, or only into the oversubscribed end?
 5. **First-destination job titles, not employment rates.**
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Questions to ask a finance program

On placement:

- What proportion of students secure a relevant internship, and with whom?
- What's the internship-to-full-time conversion rate?
- When does careers support begin — which year, which term?

On outcomes:

- What job titles did last year's graduates hold at six months?
- What proportion went into banking, versus advisory, risk or corporate finance?
- How has that mix shifted in three years?

On the curriculum:

- How much is genuinely quantitative, and is it compulsory?
- How does the programme teach students to work with AI analysis tools — and to check them?

Red flags: outcomes quoted as employment rate; careers support starting in year two or later; placement into a narrow set of employers only; a curriculum unchanged since 2022.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Financial Analysts — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. The primary source for growth projections and wage distributions, free and updated regularly. Read this before any recruiting-firm forecast.
- **Investment Banking USA Hiring Outlook 2026** — Selby Jennings. Useful for where demand is actually concentrated — restructuring, private capital, secondaries, technology and infrastructure — and for the observation that hiring is strongest at associate and VP level. Note this is a recruiting firm; read it for the directional picture rather than as neutral analysis.
- **Are too many students choosing finance?** — on the split between oversubscribed glamorous roles and under-filled ones. The most useful corrective to how students actually apply.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 8.0 is that we are scoring a **cycle** and calling it a **structure**.

Deal activity collapsed in 2023–24 and analyst hiring collapsed with it. Both have since recovered, and industry commentary now describes banks as understaffed against rebounding transaction volume. On this reading, the entry-level compression we're measuring is the ordinary bottom of a cycle that has already turned, and attributing it to AI mistakes timing for causation.

Where we land: we take this seriously enough to have written it into section 5 rather than leaving it here, and it is the single largest source of uncertainty in this profile. What holds our score is that the content of the first-year role has changed even where the headcount recovers — when firms interview for the ability to direct AI through modelling rather than to build models, the apprenticeship has been redesigned regardless of how many seats exist.

But if analyst classes return to pre-2023 size and the work returns with them, we are wrong and we will lower the score. That is a specific, falsifiable claim and we'll report it either way.

Bottom line

Finance's protected end is genuinely protected, and it is not where students are looking.

Wealth advisory at 4.6 and risk at 5.3 are shielded by the two things that hold up across this whole index: a named human answerable to a client, and regulatory obligation attached to a person. Neither is going anywhere.

The entry tier is the problem, and it is severe — 8.0, with a job description that reads like a list of automated tasks. Hiring has shifted toward experience, and the training the analyst years used to provide has changed even where the seats remain.

And the practical advice is unusually concrete for this profile. Understand the recruiting timeline, because it starts eighteen months ahead of the job and the internship is now the filter rather than one input among several. A student interested in this needs to know that in their first year, not their third.

So: aim at advisory, risk or compliance rather than assuming banking, take the quantitative modules seriously because verification depends on them, get the internship, and move toward being answerable to someone as early as you can.

And one honest thing worth saying. The advisory end of finance — sitting with someone making the most consequential financial decision of their life and being the person they trust — is work people describe in terms very close to vocation. It scores 4.6, it hires readily, and almost nobody applies to it. That combination is rare.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made finance appealing? Push past "I'm good with numbers" or "it pays well" to something specific. 2. **Banking, or advisory?** They're genuinely different careers with different hours, different clients and a 3.4-point gap in exposure. 3. What does a Tuesday look like in the job they're imagining? What about a Tuesday at 11pm? 4. Are they drawn to the money, the problem-solving, or the relationships? Those lead different places.

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Wealth advisory scores 4.6 and entry analyst 8.0. Does that change where they'd aim? 6. The profile says the entry-analyst job description reads like a list of automated tasks. Does that land? 7. Everyone applies to banking; far fewer apply to advisory and risk, which score better. What do they make of that?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

8. **The timeline.** Summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months ahead. Do they understand that the decision effectively happens in first year? 9. The hours at the banking end, through their twenties. Have they pictured that concretely? 10. Hiring concentrates in a few financial centres. Is relocating appealing or a problem?

Part 2c — The other side

11. Of what people find rewarding — consequence, pace of learning, variety, optionality, the advisory relationship — which two matter most? 12. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then compare. 13. Can they build trust with people older and wealthier than them? That's the advisory core and it's testable.

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

14. Firms now interview for the ability to *direct* AI through modelling rather than build models. What does that tell them about what to practise? 15. Analysts used to learn a sector by modelling everything in it. If that's automated, how do they think they'd learn instead?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

16. **The most valuable single action:** find someone two to three years into finance and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that work still exists. 17. Have they spoken to anyone in wealth advisory or risk, as opposed to banking? The picture is very different.

Part 4 — About the program

18. Ask each programme the internship and conversion questions from section 13. 19. **When does careers support begin?** If it's year two, that's already late for banking. 20. What proportion of graduates go into advisory, risk or corporate finance rather than banking?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

21. Have they compared this properly against accounting? Licensed CPA advisory scores 5.2 against entry finance at 8.0 — worse pay, better protection, and a licence. 22. If finance weren't available, what would they choose? 23. Do they want *finance*, or what finance is made of — consequence, money, problem-solving, status? Those point in genuinely different directions.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

24. Am I attracted to the prestige of this on their behalf? Honest answer. 25. Do I understand how early the recruiting process actually starts? 26. Am I comfortable with the hours and the geography if it goes the banking route? 27. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For finance specifically, we've flagged that this is the most cyclical profession we score, that some of the measured movement is likely the deal cycle rather than automation, and that we cannot cleanly separate the two.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.